existed the walled town of Qurghan and an interesting mountain, known as the Bara-Kukh.[7] The mountain was symmetric which made it appear gorgeous all the time.

In AD 1496 (902 AH), Sultān Mahmud Khān had built two retreats. One atop the hill and the other below with an interesting porch. Babur mentions that although Mahmud Khān's retreat existed higher, his one was better placed, with the whole of the town and the suburbs being at its foot.

The stream that passed through Andijān, reached there only after traversing the green belts of Osh. Either side of the banks was surrounded by orchards. The tulips and roses blossomed in the springs. This made the panorama of orchids appear more pleasing than anything around.

On the periphery of the Bara-Kukh existed a mosque called the Jauza Masjid (Twin Mosque). The great main canal flowing from the hill separated the mosque and the town. A dappled meadow full of clovers existed below the outer court of the mosque. It was the resting place for the travellers. Just a few years before the accidental demise of Babur's father, Umar Shaikh Mīrzā, a peculiar stone was discovered in Bara-Kukh. It had an unusual tint of red and white. People had begun making knife handles, belt clasps, etc. from the stone.

The other important city of Ferghana was Margilan[8] located to the west of Andijān. It was said to be a fine settlement full of good things such as an excellent crop of apricots and pomegranates. The city had a different kind of pomegranate, which they called the Dana-i-Kalan, and its sweetness was akin to the pleasant flavour of the small apricot. It was supposed to be much better than the Semnan[9] pomegranate.

Babur in general didn't have a very pleasant opinion of the people of Margilan for they were bullies in his eyes. He found them noisy and tempestuous. But he goes on to shower praises for the author of *Al-Hidayah,*[10] Burhan al-Din al-Margilali. He was a Margilanian from the village of Rashdan.

Esfara[11] [*] was another township of Ferghana, lying south-west of Margilan. Like other townships, even Esfara had a running stream of water. It had little but beautiful gardens and many orchards, most of which were covered with almonds. The townsfolk spoke Persian mostly, unlike other parts of Ferghana which were already Turkified. A piece of rock known as 'mirror stone' existed towards the hills, two miles south of the town. It got